A GUIDE FOR STUDENTS

Writing Like an Oxbridge Student

How to build a clear, persuasive argument

Writing sits at the heart of studying at Oxford and Cambridge. It runs through your application, from your personal statement to any written work you submit, and once you arrive, you may write an essay or more every week.

The good news is that strong academic writing isn't a gift that some people have and others don't. It's a skill anyone can learn. This guide shows you what good writing looks like and how to build a clear, persuasive argument step by step.

SECTION ONE

What good academic writing looks like

A clear argument

Good essays answer the question directly and take a clear position, rather than simply describing what they know about a topic.

Logical development

Each idea builds on the last, so the reader can follow the argument from beginning to end.

Evidence

Claims are supported by evidence, examples or reasoning, not just asserted.

Engagement with other views

Strong writing acknowledges other perspectives and explains why the writer's view holds up against them.

Precise, readable language

Words are chosen carefully, sentences are clear, and nothing is there just to sound impressive.

> **WORTH KNOWING**
> Tutors value clarity over complexity. Impressive writing makes difficult ideas easy to follow. It doesn't make simple ideas hard to follow.

SECTION TWO

Writing an essay, step by step

1 Understand the question

Before you do anything else, work out exactly what the question is asking. Look closely at its key words, such as “assess”, “compare” or “to what extent”, and notice any assumptions built into it.

TRY THIS

- Underline the key words in the question and put it into your own words.
- Ask yourself what a strong answer would need to cover.

2 Decide what you think

An essay needs a clear line of argument. Once you’ve done your reading and thinking, decide what your answer to the question is before you start writing.

TRY THIS

- Write your answer to the question in one or two sentences.
- Use that sentence to guide everything you write.

3 Plan your structure

Map out how each paragraph will build your case. A good plan makes the essay far easier to write and much easier to follow.

TRY THIS

- Write one line for each paragraph, saying what point it will make.
- Check that every paragraph moves your argument forward.

4 Write strong paragraphs

Each paragraph should make one clear point. Open with that point, support it with evidence or reasoning, and show how it connects to your overall argument.

TRY THIS

- Check that the first sentence of each paragraph states its main point.
- End each paragraph by linking it back to the question.

5 Deal with counterarguments

Show that you've considered other views. Explaining why an opposing argument is weaker, or how your view accounts for it, makes your own argument stronger.

TRY THIS

- Identify the strongest objection to your argument.
- Explain clearly why your view still holds.

6 Conclude with purpose

Your conclusion should bring your argument together and make its significance clear, rather than simply repeating what you've already said.

TRY THIS

- Summarise your answer to the question in fresh words.
- Finish by explaining why your argument matters.

SECTION THREE

Writing clearly

Keep key sentences short

Use short, direct sentences for your most important points, so they stand out.

Signpost your argument

Words and phrases such as "however", "as a result" and "this suggests" show the reader how your ideas connect.

Choose precise words

Pick the word that says exactly what you mean, rather than a vaguer or grander alternative.

Cut what isn't needed

Remove words, phrases and sentences that don't add anything. Shorter is often stronger.

Explain your terms

Only use technical vocabulary you understand and could explain. If a term is important, define it.

SECTION FOUR

Common pitfalls

Describing instead of arguing

Retelling what you know about a topic isn't the same as answering the question. Every paragraph should support your argument.

Sitting on the fence

Considering both sides is important, but you still need to reach a clear judgement.

Listing points without connecting them

An essay is more than a series of separate points. Show how your ideas relate to each other.

Over-quoting

Quotations should support your argument, not replace it. Use them sparingly and always explain their significance.

Using complicated language to sound clever

Long words and complex sentences can hide your ideas. Clear writing is more convincing.

SECTION FIVE

Improving your writing

Read your work aloud

Hearing your writing helps you catch clumsy phrasing, unclear sentences and gaps in your argument.

Redraft

Good writing is almost always rewritten. Expect to revise your work more than once.

Learn from good writers

Notice how the best writers in your subject build arguments, use evidence and structure their work.

Ask for feedback

Feedback is one of the fastest ways to improve. Your Access Oxbridge mentor can review your writing and help you strengthen your arguments, and your teachers can offer valuable comments too.

Before you hand in an essay

- [ ] I've answered the question that was asked
- [ ] I've addressed other views
- [ ] My argument is clear from the start
- [ ] My conclusion does more than repeat
- [ ] Each paragraph makes one clear point
- [ ] I've cut unnecessary words
- [ ] My points are supported by evidence
- [ ] I've read it aloud and redrafted

Where to find official information

Details such as admissions tests, deadlines and course requirements can change from year to year. Always check the latest information on the official websites:

- **University of Oxford undergraduate admissions:** ox.ac.uk/admissions/undergraduate
- **University of Cambridge undergraduate study:** undergraduate.study.cam.ac.uk
- **UCAS:** ucas.com